USER GUIDE · FOR JUDGES

Ballast

Plan your week by how much it takes out of you, not how many hours it fills.

😩 THE PROBLEM

Students burn out because planners count hours, not energy. A bad week is only noticed once it has already happened.

🎮 DEMO · NO LOGIN

load-balancer-ballast--demo.expo.app

A ready-made student week. Resets on every reload.

📱 THE REAL APP

load-balancer-ballast.expo.app

Sign in with a judge account (page 2) or your own.

👩‍⚖️ Judges' suggestions

1 · Read this guide first. It's short, and it makes the app quicker to pick up.

2 · Start with the demo link. Ballast works on each user's own week, so a new account starts empty. The demo is a mostly functional preview with a full, ready-made week. Explore it before creating your own brand-new account.

3 · Try the social side with real accounts. Our key social features need real people, so we set up **five real judge accounts** who are all friends. Open a few at the same time and follow **page 8**.

⚠️ **The five accounts are shared by every judge. Please play, but don't wreck them.**
✅ Go ahead: add tasks, mark classes, check in, book sittings, accept or decline plans, send invites, rebalance.
🚫 Please don't: **change the password**, **sign out other devices**, **delete groups**, **remove friends**, or **connect your own Google Calendar** to them.
If something does get messed up, we can rebuild all five in about a minute.

Have fun! 🎉

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30 SECONDS · NO APP STORE NEEDED

Download & install

📱 THE APP

load-balancer-ballast.expo.app

Scan with your phone camera

🎮 DEMO · NO LOGIN

load-balancer-ballast--demo.expo.app

Resets on every reload

🍎 iPhone · Safari

1. Open the app link (or scan)
2. Tap **Share** ⬆ at the bottom
3. **Add to Home Screen** → **Add**
4. Open **Ballast** from your home screen

🤖 Android · Chrome

1. Open the app link (or scan)
2. Tap the menu ⋮ (top right)
3. **Install app** → **Install**
4. Open **Ballast** from your home screen

💻 On a laptop: any browser works. It's designed for phones, so a narrow window looks best.

ALL FRIENDS WITH EACH OTHER

Judge accounts

Password for all five: `BallastDemo2026`

STUDENT	EMAIL	THEIR WEEK	TRY
💻 **Aisyah**	`aisyah.ballast@example.com`	A wall next week	Red wall → **Lighten**
🧪 **Priya**	`priya.ballast@example.com`	Running on empty	**Recovery**
📊 **Daniel**	`daniel.ballast@example.com`	Steady, barista shifts	**Plans** → **Sent**
🏗️ **Hafiz**	`hafiz.ballast@example.com`	Design crunch	Birthday dinner answers
🎨 **Mei Ling**	`meiling.ballast@example.com`	The calm one	Invites in the 🔔

⚠️ **Shared by every judge.** Please don't change the password, sign out other devices, delete groups, remove friends, or connect Google Calendar.

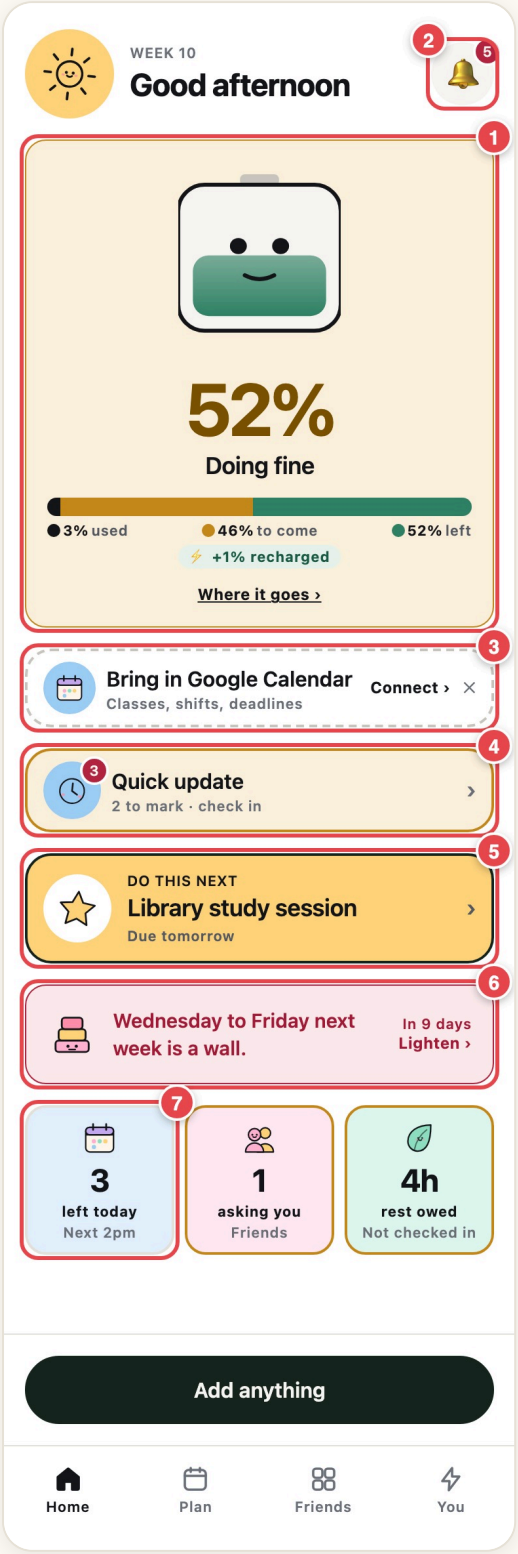
💡 **Want a blank slate?** Create your own account. Setup is four short steps, all skippable.

YOUR WHOLE WEEK IN ONE LOOK

Home

THE PROBLEM

Planners show how many hours are booked, not how drained you'll be, so burnout is only noticed when it's too late.



1. **Your battery**
   100% each Monday. Every commitment takes a share.
2. **Bell**
   Invites, answers, deadlines
3. **Google Calendar**
   Bring your events in
4. **Quick update**
   Mark classes ✓ ✕, check in
5. **Do this next**
   From the priority list (page 6)
6. **The wall**
   A pile-up spotted days early → **Lighten**
7. **At a glance**
   Today, friends, rest owed

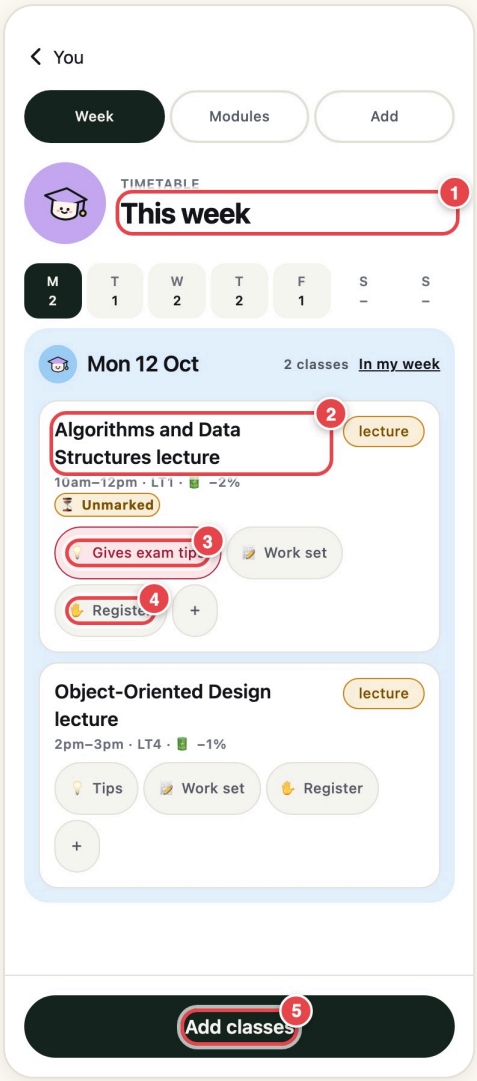
Energy, not hours. Two hours of a dreaded report cost more than two hours of badminton.

KEY FEATURE · CLASSES & ATTENDANCE

Timetable

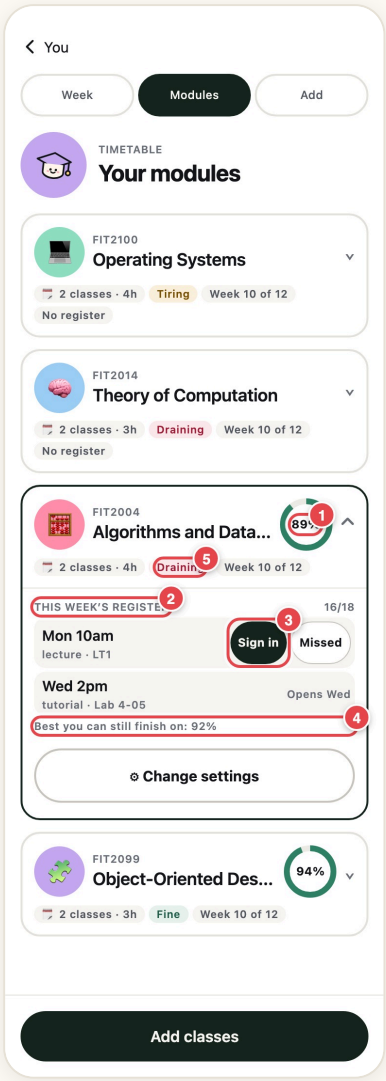
THE PROBLEM

Classes fill most of a student's week, yet planners treat them as plain events. They don't know which classes drain you, which ones count for attendance, or which ones give exam tips.



Week

1. **This week**, day by day
2. **Each class**
   With its battery cost
3. **Flags**
   Exam tips · work set. Tap to toggle.
4. **Register**
   Attendance counts here
5. **Add classes**



Modules

1. **Attendance so far**
2. **This week's register**
3. **Sign in / Missed**
   One tap after class
4. **Best you can still finish on**
5. **How draining**
   Sets each class's battery cost

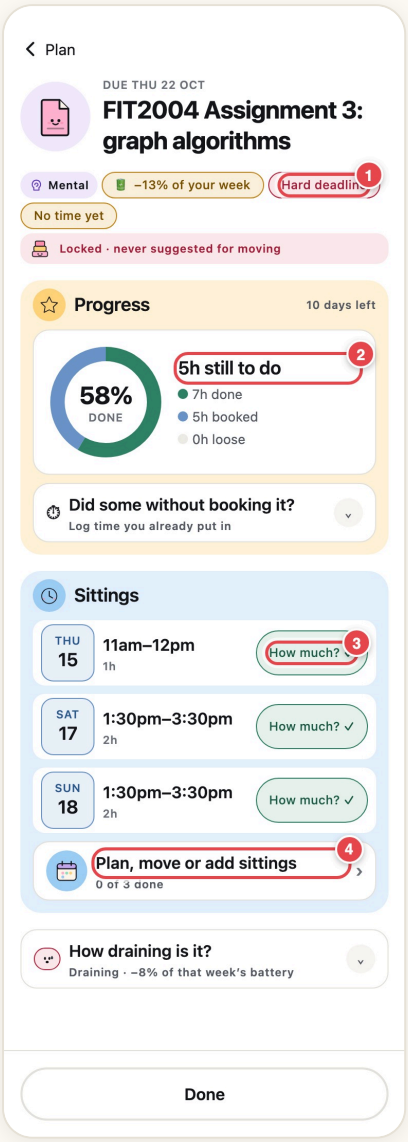
⚡ **Fast setup:** add a module, tap its days and times. Or **Paste from your portal** to bring the whole timetable in at once.

KEY FEATURE · ASSIGNMENTS AS HOURS OWED

Owing work

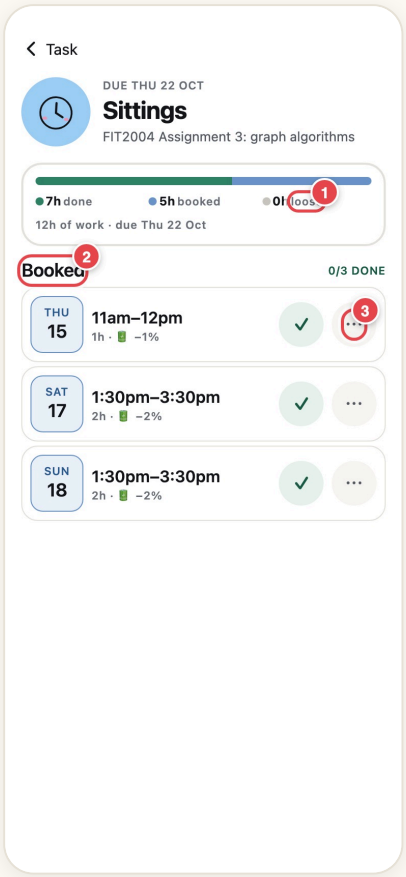
THE PROBLEM

An assignment isn't one event, it's hours of work you owe. Planners only note the deadline, so the work lands the night before.



The assignment

1. **Locked**
   Hard deadlines never move
2. **Progress**
   Done · booked · loose
3. **How much?**
   Log progress after a sitting
4. **Plan sittings**



Its sittings

1. **Done · booked · loose**
2. **Booked sittings**
   Each with its battery cost
3. **··· Move or give back**

✨ Suggest

Hours still loose? Ballast proposes sittings on your **lightest days**, each with a reason. Nothing is booked until you say so.

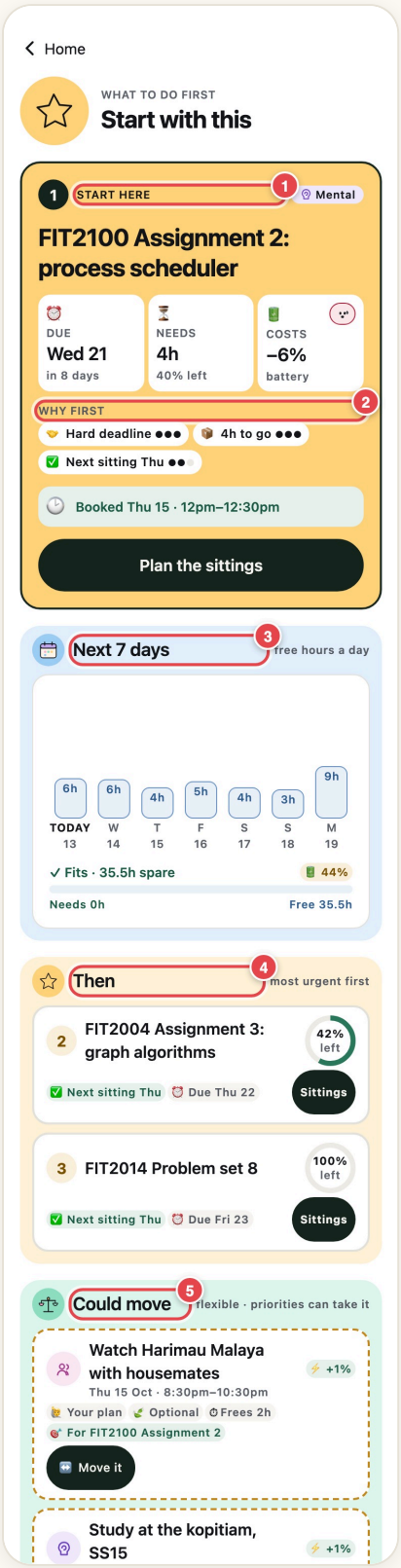
✍️ **Add one:** tap **Add anything** and type it how you'd say it: *"Networks report, Thursday, 5h, dreading it"*.

KEY FEATURE · WHAT TO DO FIRST

Priority list

THE PROBLEM

With ten things due, students burn energy just deciding what to do first, and usually pick the easy thing.



1. **Start here**
   Due date, hours needed, battery cost
2. **Why first**
   Real reasons: ⏰ Due Wed · 3h free till then, 🤝 Hard deadline, with 1–3 dots
3. **Next 7 days**
   Free hours a day · one bar: needs vs. free
4. **Then**
   Most urgent first · ⏰ due · ⏳ hours left · rank colour = how soon
5. **Could move**
   Flexible time your priorities can take: ⏱ Frees 2h · 🎯 For Assignment 2

🧱 How it ranks

By the day you have to **start**: walking back from the deadline through your real free time. So 12 hours due next week can come before 1 hour due tomorrow. Importance (🍃 → 🔥) decides within a day. 📌 Fixed plans never appear.

✨ AI headline

A line of advice on top and a short why on each row. The order itself comes from our own model, so it's explainable and stays the same each time.

🗓️ Change the time · Move it

One picker everywhere: this week and next with **how full each day is** (or 📅 a calendar), then **drag the block** along the day. 🟧 **Amber** blocks can be given up: slide onto one to take its place. **Move it** gives that time to the 🎯 task, then re-homes the block. 🗑️ **Cancel** asks twice.

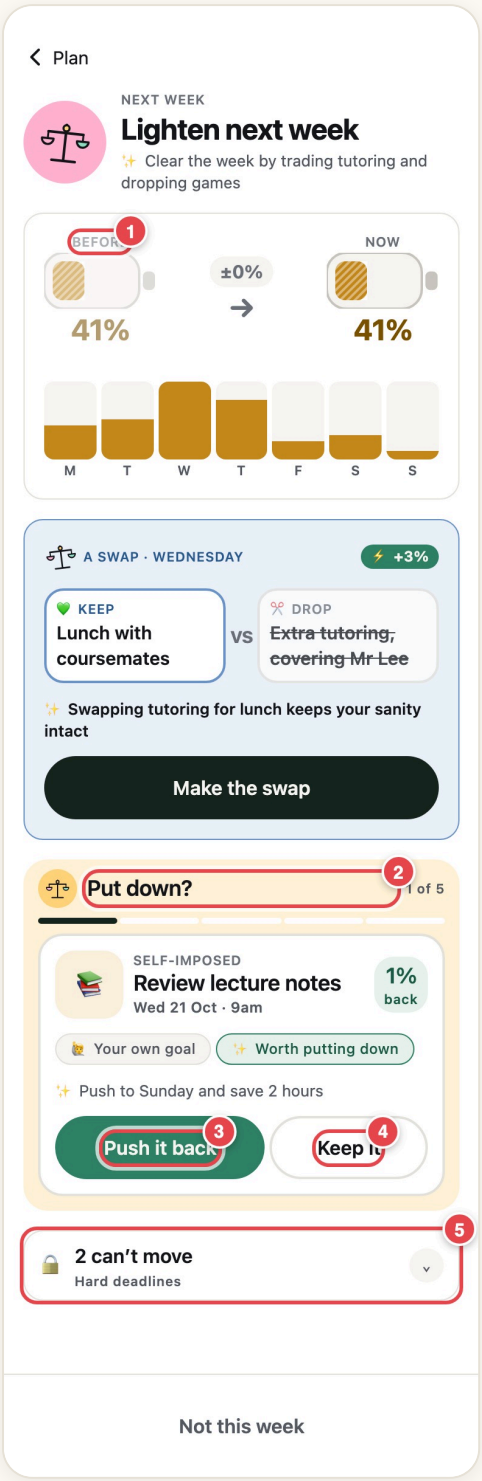
Find it: **Home** → **Do this next**, or **Plan** → **What to do first**.

TRADING, NOT DELETING

Lighten next week

THE PROBLEM

When a week is too much, people cancel at random, often the wrong thing, then dread the message they have to send.



1. **Before → now**
   Updates as you decide
2. **One decision at a time**
   With an ✨ AI opinion and its reason
3. **Push it back**
   Or hand it over, or put it down
4. **Keep it**
5. **Hard deadlines**
   Listed, never offered

A swap

Keep what recharges you, drop what doesn't. One tap.

Someone waiting on it?

Ballast offers to **write the message first** (page 10).

Try it: **Aisyah** → red wall card → **Lighten**.

Social · try it with real accounts

😩 **THE PROBLEM**

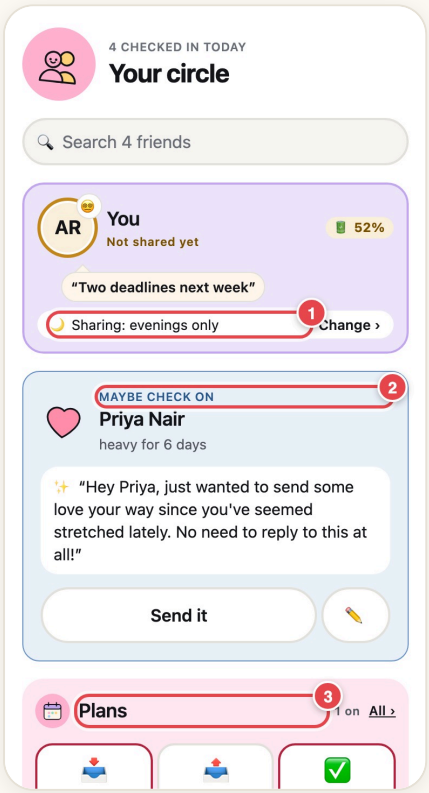
In busy weeks friends drift apart. Nobody knows who's free or who's struggling, and "when are you free?" goes nowhere.

🧪 Two accounts, side by side

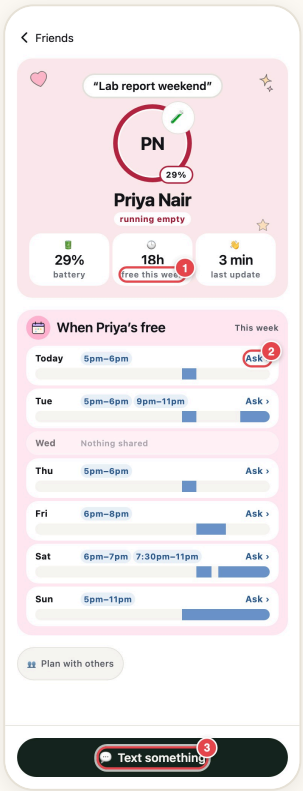
One account per browser: a normal window + a private (incognito) window, or phone + laptop.

1. **Window A:** sign in as Daniel. **Window B:** sign in as Mei Ling.
2. Daniel → **Friends** → **Plan something together** → **Mei Ling** → **Dinner**.
3. Tap the 🟩 **green block** (both free) → **Invite**.
4. Mei Ling → 🔔 **bell** → **Accept**. It lands in her week.
5. Daniel → **Plans** → **Confirmed** → **Add to week**.
6. Bonus: Mei Ling **checks in** with a note → Daniel sees it on **Friends**.

Updates arrive within a minute. Reload to see them instantly.



1. **How much you share**
2. **Maybe check on…**
   A friend having a heavy week
3. **Plans** · received, sent, confirmed



1. **Battery & free hours**
2. **Shared evenings** · tap **Ask**
3. 💬 **Text something** → page 10

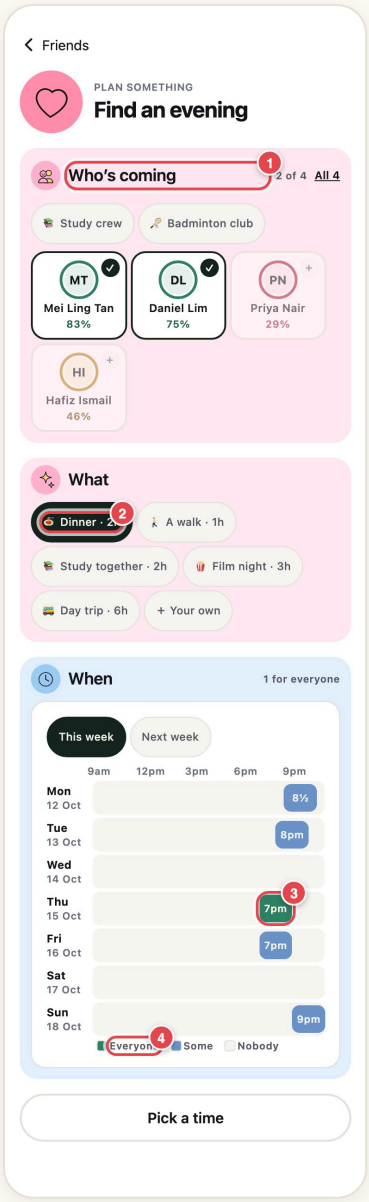


⭐ KEY FEATURE · FROM "WHEN ARE YOU FREE?" TO A PLAN

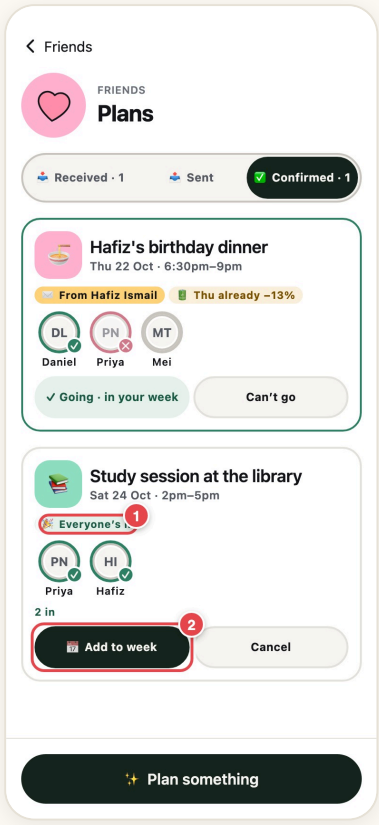
Social · plan together

😩 **THE PROBLEM**

Finding one evening that works for everyone takes a dozen messages, and plans fall through.



1. **Who's coming** · faces or a group
2. **What** · sets the length
3. 🟩 **Everyone free** · tap it
4. 🟦 **Some free**



1. 🎉 **Everyone's in**
2. **Add to week**
   Once all have answered. Someone can't? **Go ahead with 2.**

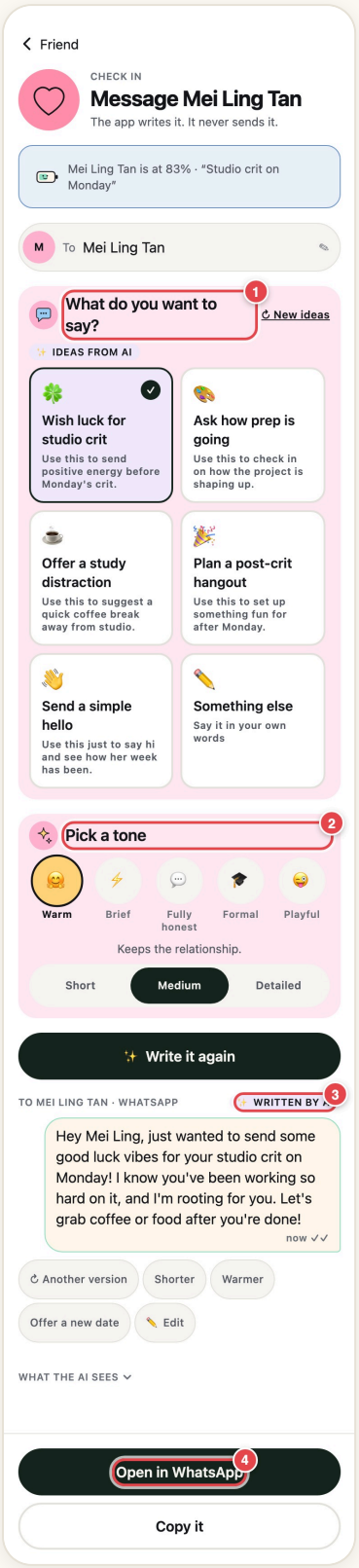
📩 Got invited?

See **how full that day already is**, then **Accept**. It goes in your week, moves if the host moves it, and leaves if it's called off.

Write a message

😩 THE PROBLEM

Saying no, or checking on a struggling friend, is the hardest message to write, so it often never gets sent.



1. **What do you want to say?**
   ✨ Ideas that fit them and their week
2. **Pick a tone**
   Warm · brief · honest · formal · playful, and a length
3. ✨ **Written by AI**
   Shorter, warmer, another version, or edit
4. **Open in WhatsApp**
   Or copy it. Ballast never sends anything itself.

📍 Where it opens

1. A friend's page → 💬 **Text something**
2. **Maybe check on…** on Friends → ✏️
3. **Saying no**: from Lighten next week, or **Write the message** on the priority list

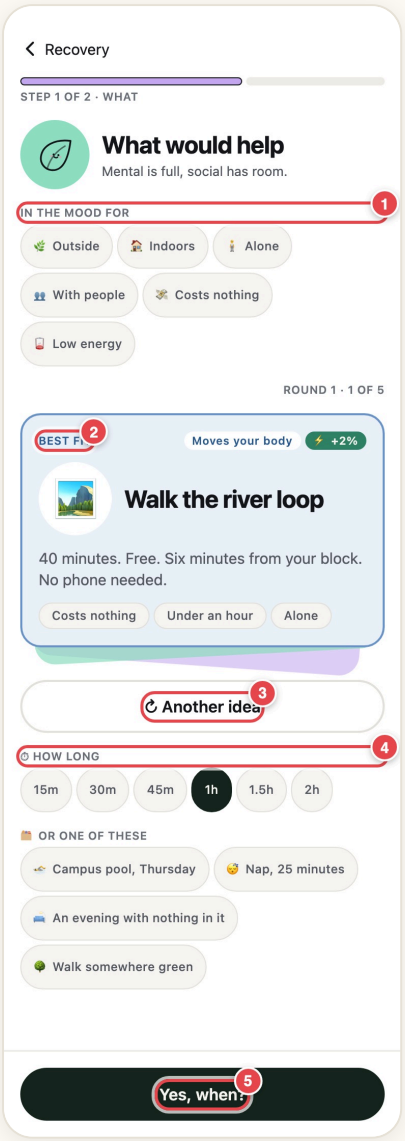
🔒 **What the AI sees** is shown on the page: just what the message is about, never your whole week.

REST YOU CAN ACTUALLY PLAN

Recovery

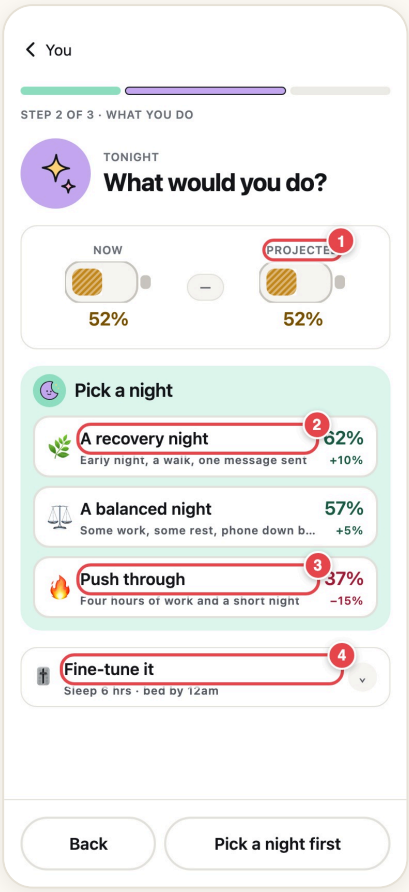
THE PROBLEM

Rest is the first thing students drop, and "just rest" isn't a plan.



What would actually help

1. **In the mood for**
   Outside, alone, free, low energy...
2. **Best fit**
   For the area that's fullest, with what it gives back
3. **Another idea**
4. **How long**
5. **Yes, when?** · book it in a real gap



Plan tonight

1. **Now → projected**
   Your battery after the night
2. **A recovery night**
   Early night, a walk: +10%
3. **Push through**
   See what it really costs: −15%
4. **Fine-tune it**
   Sleep and bedtime

Rest bank: short sleeps and long days add up to rest you're owed. **Home → rest owed.**

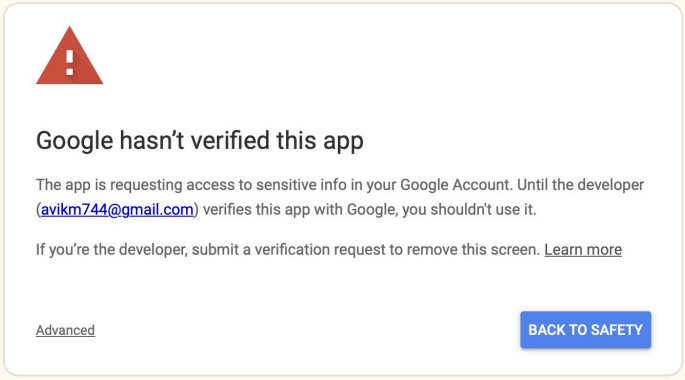
READ-ONLY · EVENTS NEVER STORED

Google Calendar

😩 THE PROBLEM

Your classes and shifts already live in Google Calendar. Typing them in twice is a chore nobody keeps up.

⚠️ "Google hasn't verified this app"



1. Tap **Advanced**
2. Tap **Go to Ballast (unsafe)**
3. Allow **read-only** calendar access

It works fully after that, and nothing else in the app is affected.

🤝 Why: a trade-off

Reading a calendar is a "sensitive" Google permission. Removing this screen needs Google's verification review, which takes weeks. We shipped the feature now rather than leave it out.

✨ Once connected

Events become cards, with a guess at what each is (class, deadline, shift). Weekly classes are set up once. Moved events follow.

🙏 Use **your own account** for this, not a judge account.

🛟 Known issues & tips

A friend's update isn't there yet	Sync runs about every minute. **Reload** to see it now.
Judge numbers differ from this guide	Batteries move as the week goes; others may be using the account.
The demo changed back	By design: it resets on reload. Demo friends answer by themselves.
An ✨ AI line looks plainer	If Gemini is busy (free tier), Ballast writes it itself, so nothing breaks.
First load is slow	The server wakes after idle time. Once, for a second or two.
No App Store version	It's a web app installed from the link (page 2). Pop-ups work while it's open.
Up to 100 Google accounts	Google's limit for apps awaiting verification.

Thanks for trying Ballast 🫙 · kcchung82@gmail.com